

6, The Success of the Restoration-Bureaucratic System

In the late 6th and early 7th centuries CE, the rulers of the empire possessed a clear historical memory of China's prolonged division and fragmentation since the end of the Jin Dynasty. Even if they could not recognize it from a scientific perspective, they could determine through intuition and experience that in order to maintain the absolute authority of the monarch, they must find ways to suppress the still-existing *aristocratic great clans* (门阀士族).

Fortunately for the rulers, technological advancements not only allowed *feudalization* (封建化) to deepen but could equally be utilized by the emperor. Among these, papermaking and woodblock printing played a particularly monumental role. Thus, besides continuing to employ administrative power to weaken the economic strength and political influence of the *aristocratic great clans*, the empire was able to take a decisive step in the system of official selection: the implementation of the Imperial Examination (*Keju* / 科举).

For the monarch, the *Keju* powerfully weakened the ability of the *feudal landlord class* (封建地主阶级) to translate its economic status into political status, curbing the formation of a unified *class interests coalition* (阶级利益共同体). The *Keju* would completely terminate the influence caused by elite lineage politics since the Han and Wei dynasties, centralizing personnel power into the hands of the central government, especially the emperor, thereby enhancing the extractive capacity of the *bureaucratic state* (官僚国家).

Beyond direct political and economic benefits, by transforming intellectuals into "disciples of the Son of Heaven" (天子门生), the emperor would create a public opinion environment far more favorable to himself and detrimental to the aristocratic clans. By determining the content of the *Keju* examinations and promoting officially sanctioned doctrines, the *bureaucratic state's* ideological control over the entire society was unprecedentedly strengthened.

Therefore, a specific event is recorded in the *Tang Zhiyan* (《唐摭言》): when Emperor Taizong, Li Shimin (太宗皇帝李世民), saw the successful candidates of the imperial examination marching out in single file from the Duanmen Gate, he joyfully remarked to his attendants, "*The heroes under heaven have entered my net*" (天下英雄入吾彀中矣). Viewed from today, 1400 years later, Li Shimin was indeed qualified to express such a sigh of triumph, because from then on, China embarked on a path untrodden by any other nation.

Of course, the aftershocks of the ethnic minority conquests would still ripple for a century. Although the most turbulent wave of *feudalization* was blocked by the breakwater of the bureaucratic system, as long as the *feudal mode of production* (封建生产方式) remained mainstream in the empire, the landlord class's assault on the bureaucratic system could not completely cease.

Beginning with the An Lushan Rebellion (安史之乱), feudalized *Fanzhen* (藩镇 - regional military commands) emerged in the Hebei region, engaging in *de facto* warlord separatism. Comparing the regions controlled by the *Fanzhen* with the regions subjected to wealth extraction by the court, the lives of the common people in the former were paradoxically more stable. Not only were the frequency and intensity of peasant uprisings lower, but archaeological evidence also supports that the people's average lifespan was longer.

However, it must be pointed out that the *feudalization* primarily manifested by the *Fanzhen* during the middle and late Tang Dynasty could not remotely compare in intensity to that of the Sixteen

Kingdoms and the Northern and Southern Dynasties. This is reflected not only in the fact that the *Fanzhen* nominally remained subordinate to the Tang Empire—possessing the ability to defend themselves for a period but lacking the capacity to conquer the realm.

More importantly, the *Fanzhen* of the Tang Dynasty could not form stable feudal relations. In particular, the core military force of the *Fanzhen*, the *Yabing* (牙兵 - headquarters guards), did not provide military service based on being granted land as a reward. This caused the *Fanzhen* themselves to be exceptionally unstable, especially during succession. Realistically speaking, the conscription system universally implemented by the *Fanzhen* was identical to the court's—a mercenary/recruitment system (募兵制). Naturally, it was impossible to establish a stable lord-vassal system like a true feudal regime.

Although the *Fanzhen* of the middle and late Tang and the Five Dynasties could be said to contain certain *feudalization* factors, they were still a far cry from feudal regimes. Thus, the counterattack of the *bureaucratic state* was an unstoppable inevitability. From the Tang to the Five Dynasties, perhaps only the notorious traitor in Chinese history, Shi Jingtang(石敬瑭), was subjectively willing to adopt certain measures that were in fact conducive to feudalization (though he may not have pursued these actions with feudalization as his explicit goal). These included relaxing the state's control over the economy, allowing merchants to question whether taxation was rational and legal, lifting the state monopoly on salt and iron, and so on. However, he was still unable to resolve the critical issue of establishing a stable feudal hierarchical order. Consequently, his benevolent policies ultimately proved to be nothing more than a fleeting flash in the pan.

The restoration of the *bureaucratic state* (官僚国家) was ultimately completed by the Song Empire. The most crucial historical roles were played by the founding emperor, Song Taizu (Zhao Kuangyin), and his younger brother, Taizong (Zhao Guangyi).

After a century of slaughter during the late Tang and Five Dynasties, factors favorable to the *bureaucratic state* were increasing. One such factor was the relative decrease of un-feudalized barbarians within *Handi* (China Proper / 汉地)—having become indistinguishable from the Han people after bureaucratization, or having been annihilated in wars. History from five centuries prior had already demonstrated that these tribal groups themselves were a crucial factor promoting *feudalization* (封建化).

Although the Song rulers could not comprehend the *feudalization* process from a scientific perspective, they discovered through historical experience that peripheral barbarian nations always seemed to be destroying China's inherent system. The Song Dynasty consistently maintained a cautious distance from the barbarians, even expressing an extreme lack of interest in the former territories of the Han and Tang dynasties, harboring a certain pride in its own purity.

Additionally, the economic development of the South and the Grand Canal also favored the court's rule. The Song rulers could easily note from the history of previous eras that when Northern China fell into severe *Fanzhen* (warlord) separatism, the court in Chang'an relied entirely on the tax revenues of the Jiangnan provinces to sustain itself. During the more than half-century of the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms (which can be traced back to the An Lushan Rebellion), the economy of Southern China underwent further development, while the North became relatively weakened due to the ravages of war.

The unique geographical environment of the South placed the court in an extremely advantageous position. Ever since the Qin and Han empires first conquered this vast region, the Han people continuously strengthened their local control through wars of expulsion against the Baiyue (and other ethnic groups), a process that lasted until China's final dynasty, the Qing. Although such armed pioneering would spawn a certain degree of feudal organization—in fact, even today, the lineage clans (宗族) of Southern China are far beyond comparison with the highly atomized (原子化) northern plains. However, the newly pioneered territories in the South lacked large, contiguous plains and were divided by hilly and mountainous terrain. Thus, it was difficult to form relatively concentrated political forces like the samurai in Japan's Kantō region, and consequently, they were always kept under the court's control.

By the final stage of the empire, *Late Imperial China* (中华帝国晚期), relatively obvious regional divisions of labor had emerged nationwide. This vastly differed from the situation during the first millennium CE, where regional political and economic centers overlapped; the unified *bureaucratic state* thereby became more consolidated.

Therefore, we can deduce that during the Song Dynasty, the rulers certainly realized that extracting social wealth from the South via the Grand Canal would consolidate central finances, thereby giving them the spare capacity to eradicate the influence of the Five Dynasties' *Fanzhen*. This also suffices to explain why Song Taizu resolutely established the capital in Kaifeng. It was obviously not a matter of "relying on virtue rather than geographic defenses" (在德不在险); rather, it was a manifestation of the Song rulers consistently placing the priority of internal stability far above foreign relations. Ending the aftershocks of *feudalization* following prolonged chaos was the paramount task, rather than considering the not-yet-imminent threats from foreign nations.

Of course, aside from these favorable factors, the Song rulers further exerted their subjective agency. They enhanced the role of the imperial examination in the selection and appointment of officials and expanded their co-optation of the landlord class. Consequently, by the Song Dynasty, the *aristocratic great clans* (门阀世家) that had formed since the Eastern Han essentially vanished.

The Song Empire's outstanding fiscal extractive capacity (财政汲取能力) also enabled the court to provision an exceptionally massive standing army. Today, we should no longer believe that when the Song rulers created this army, they expected it to defeat the elite forces of foreign nations. Instead, there is ample reason to believe that the primary mission of this army was to maintain the internal stability of the empire.

For instance, the Song Dynasty's bloated and unwieldy army absorbed massive numbers of vagrants (流民). Left unchecked, these vagrants would either foment rebellions or be absorbed by major landlords in various regions—both outcomes would challenge the unquestionable power of the court. If these unemployed and propertyless young men were all conscripted into the army, it practically eliminated a colossal risk for the court. This is highly analogous to the massive army maintained by North Korea today. Rather than taking South Korea as its hypothetical enemy, North Korea's colossal ground force is better understood as taking the over 20 million North Korean people as its hypothetical enemy; its sole significance is merely to maintain the rule of the Kim family.

Emperor Taizong, Zhao Guangyi, went a step further. As soon as he annihilated Northern Han, he ended the very concept of "local officials" by abolishing the *Jiedushi* (Military Commissioners)

holding actual power. From then on (for the vast majority of periods), officials in various localities of the Chinese Empire were essentially central metropolitan officials (京官), whose promotion, demotion, appointment, and dismissal depended entirely on the court.

The political reforms of the Song Dynasty were so successful that, over the recent millennium, rebellions by China's "local officials" became exceedingly rare compared to the previous millennium, and the bureaucratic system was never again subjected to any forceful challenge by *feudalization*.

The dynasties that existed alongside or followed the Song—namely, the Liao, Jin, Yuan, Ming, and Qing—generally speaking, all further intensified bureaucratic rule, thereby strengthening the personal despotic power of the emperor. Of course, this did not occur without any fluctuations. When ethnic minorities entered the pass (*Ru Guan* / 入关), they would initially carry certain *feudalization* (封建化) characteristics to some extent. However, no matter the ethnicity, they all engaged in varying degrees of the "Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise" (地主—官僚妥协), and none attempted to establish a feudal ruling order dominated by themselves within China's borders.

Just like that, in the first few days of October, I provided a new explanation for a crucial issue in the prolonged history of the Chinese Empire. This explanation is more scientific than any other theory I had previously known, yet thus far, there remain far too many unresolved questions. Therefore, I decided to press on while the iron was hot.

On the final day of the National Day holiday, I shared these discoveries with my closest friend, H. H expressed his trust in me; he not only believed that the "troubleshooting the circuit" process aligned with the scientific spirit, but also claimed that the most invaluable aspect of this new explanation was its abandonment of unverifiable moral inferences. Instead, reasoning through class standpoint and profit motive possesses universality and can be tested against historical events in other spatiotemporal contexts.

In the past, our country's historiography always tended to resort to morality to explain certain monumental events—for instance, asserting that a certain monarch had a guilty conscience, a certain minister possessed noble virtues, or a certain class was inherently despicable. This not only deviates from the materialist conception of history but lacks any *falsifiability* (可证伪性) whatsoever, to the point that it can hardly be considered science.

A typical example is the Rebellion of the Eight Princes (八王之乱) in the Western Jin dynasty and the subsequent chaos caused by the Five Barbarians (五胡乱华). This is invariably blamed on the low legitimacy, corrupted morals, and low intelligence of the Sima clan's rulers. Even a slightly more rational explanation is limited to seeing it merely as an overcorrection of the Cao Wei regime's policy regarding imperial clansmen.

However, once we observe from the perspective of global history as a whole, we can clearly realize that the collapse of classical empires and invasions by ethnic minorities were universal social phenomena occurring across the Eurasian continent—stretching from the British Isles all the way to Korea—and were re-enacted almost ten centuries later on the Indochinese Peninsula.

And as Newton taught us, universal phenomena demand universal explanations. It was precisely my trust in scientific principles that enabled me to instantly recognize the absurdity and ridiculousness of those old theories. This is also why, although this perspective is not yet comprehensive, I remain

intuitively full of confidence in it. I believe that by adhering to the scientific spirit, scientific principles, and scientific methods, I will inevitably reach a place no predecessor has ever reached, and behold a magnificent landscape no predecessor has ever seen.

中文原文：

6，复辟官僚制度的成功

在公元六世纪末和七世纪初，帝国的统治者对于晋末以来中国的长期分裂割据有着清晰的历史记忆，他们即使不能从科学的角度认识，也能凭借直觉和经验确定要想维护君主的绝对权威，就必须要想办法打压仍然存在的门阀士族。对统治者而言幸运的一点是，技术的进步不但使封建化得以深入，同样也可以被皇帝利用，其中起到特别巨大意义的是造纸术和雕版印刷术。于是除了继续动用行政力量削弱门阀士族的经济实力和政治影响以外，帝国得以在选官制度上迈出决定性的一步，那就是进行科举。对于君主来说，科举有力地弱化了封建地主阶级将其经济地位转化成为政治地位的能力，遏制了统一的阶级利益共同体的形成。科举将完全终结汉魏以来门阀政治造成的影响，将人事权收归中央特别是皇帝手里，增强了官僚国家的汲取能力。除了直接的政治经济上的利益以外，通过将知识分子转变成为“天子门生”，皇帝将创造更加有利于自己而不利于门阀的舆论。通过确定科举考试的内容以及推行官方认可的学说，官僚国家对全社会的思想控制史无前例地增强了。所以《唐摭言》里面记载了这样一件事，当太宗皇帝李世民于端门看到榜下进士缀行而出，高兴地对左右侍从说“天下英雄入吾彀中矣”。站在 1400 年后的今天看来，李世民的确有资格发出这般感慨，因为中国从此走上了一条其他国家都没有涉足的道路。

当然，少数民族征服的余波仍将荡漾百年，封建化最汹涌的浪潮虽然被官僚体制的防波堤拦住了，但是只要封建生产方式仍然在帝国占据主流，地主阶级对官僚体制的冲击便不可能完全停止。从安史之乱开始，河北地区出现了封建化藩镇，进行事实上的割据。现在对比藩镇控制地区和被朝廷所进行财富汲取的地区，前者百姓的生活反而更加安定，不但农民起义的次数和烈度要低，而且考古证据也支持人民的平均寿命要更长。但是必须要指出，唐中晚期以藩镇为主要表现的封建化，其强度远不能和十六国南北朝时期相比。这不仅体现在藩镇仍然在名义上从属于唐帝国，虽有能力在一段时间内自保却无法进取天下。更为重要的是，唐代的藩镇无法形成稳定的封建关系，特别是藩镇的核心军事力量牙兵并非是以在被赐以土地作为封赏的基础上提供军事服役。这就导致藩镇本身就尤为不稳定，在继承的时候更是如此。实事求是地讲，藩镇所普遍实行的兵役制度和朝廷同样都是募兵制，自然不可能像封建政权一样建立稳定的主从制度。唐中后期和五代的藩镇虽然可以说含有一定的封建化因素，但是和封建政权依然相去甚远，于是官僚国家的反攻就是难以阻挡的事情。从唐到五代，或许只有中国历史上著名的卖国贼石敬瑭在主观上愿意采取一些事实有利于封建化的举措（他做这些事情未必是以封建化为目标的），包括放松国家对经济的控制，允许商人质疑税收是否合理合法，解禁盐铁专卖等等，但是仍然无法解决确立封建等级秩序的关键问题，因此其仁政最终只是昙花一现。

官僚国家的复辟是宋帝国最终完成的，扮演最重要历史角色的是开国皇帝宋太祖赵匡胤以及其弟太宗赵光义。经过唐末五代百年的厮杀，有利于官僚国家的因素正在增多，其中之一便是未封建化的胡人在中国汉地的相对减少（在官僚化后已经变得与汉族无异了，或者在战争中被消灭），五个世纪前的历史已经表明，这些氏族部落本身就是促进封建化的一个重要因素。虽然宋朝统治者不可能从科学的角度认识封建化过程，但是他们会从历史经验中发现，周边的野蛮民族似乎总是在摧毁中国固有的体制。宋朝始终谨慎地与蛮族保持着距离，甚至极端地表示为对于汉唐故土的缺乏兴趣，并且对自己的纯洁性有一种自豪感。另外，南方经济的发展和运河也有利于朝廷的统治，宋朝统治者很容易从前代的历史中注意到，当中国北方陷入严重的藩镇割据的时候，长安的朝廷就是在依靠江南各省的税收得以维持。在五代十国的半个多世纪间（可以上溯到安史之乱），中国南方的经济得到了进一步发展，而北方因为战乱则相对衰弱了。南方特殊的地理环境使得朝廷处于一种极为有利的局面，自从秦汉帝国首次征服了这片广大的区域，汉族人就不断地在对百越人（及其他民族）的驱逐战争中加强对当地的控制，这个过程一直持续到了中国的最后一个王朝清朝。这种武装开拓虽然会催生一定程度的封建组织，实际上直到如今中国南方的宗族也远不是高度原子化的北方平原地区能够相比的。但是南方新开拓的领地缺乏大块相连的平原，被多丘陵和山脉的地形所分隔，因而难以像日本关东地区的武士一样形成较为集中的政治力量，因而总是被朝廷置于控制之下。到中华帝国的最后阶段，全国范围内已经出现了较为明显的区域分工，这与公元后的第一个千年间区域性的政治中心和经济中心重合的局面已经大为不同，统一的官僚国家因此更加稳固。

因而我们可以想到在宋代，统治者当然意识到了通过大运河汲取南方的社会财富将会巩固中央的财政，进而使其有余力去消弭五代藩镇的影响。这也足以解释为什么宋太祖赵匡胤要坚决地定都开封，显然不是什么“在德不在险”的问题，而是宋代统治者始终把安定内部的优先级远远置于对外关系之上的表现，结束长期战乱以来的封建化余波是最首要的任务，而不是考虑来自外族尚未迫在眉睫的威胁。当然除了这些有利因素以外，宋代统治者进一步发挥了主观能动性，增强了科举在选官任官中的作用，扩大了对于地主阶级的收买，因此到宋代，自东汉形成的门阀世家基本消失。宋帝国出色的财政汲取能力也使得朝廷能够供养一支极为庞大的军队，今天不应该再认为当宋朝统治者缔造这支军队的时候就指望其能够击败异族的精锐，而有理由相信这支军队的首要任务在于维持帝国内部的稳定。譬如说宋朝大而无当的军队中吸纳了大量的流民，而在不加干预的情况下，这些流民要么会掀起叛乱，要么就被各地的大地主所吸纳，这两个结果都会挑战朝廷不容置疑的权势。如果将这些无业无产的青壮年统统编入军队，那么实际上就是为朝廷消弭了一个巨大的风险。这与今天朝鲜所维持的庞大军队是非常相似的，朝鲜庞大的陆军与其说是以韩国作为假想敌，不如说是与 2000 多万朝鲜人民作为假想敌，其意义不过是维护金家的统治罢了。太宗皇帝赵光义则更进一步，一俟消灭北汉，便通过撤销实权节度使结束了“地方官”这个概念，从此以后（绝大部分时期），中华帝国在地方各地的官员本质上都是京官，其升降任免完全取决于朝廷。宋朝的政治改革是如此的成功，以至于在最近一个千年中国的“地方官员”的叛乱比起上一个千年变得少之又少，官僚体制再也没有受到过封建化的有力挑战。

与宋并列以及之后的朝代，辽、金、元、明、清总体来讲都进一步强化了官僚统治，从而加强了皇帝个人的专制权力。当然也不是没有任何波动，入关的少数民族在最初多少会带有一些封建化特征，但是无论哪个民族都进行不同程度的地主—官僚妥协，而没有试图在中国境内建立他们主导的封建统治秩序。

就这样，在十月份最初的几日里，我对中华帝国漫长历史中的一个重要问题给出了新的解释。这个解释比我之前所知道的其他理论都更为科学，但是迄今为止仍然有太多没有解决的问题，因此我决定乘胜追击。在国庆假期的最后一天，我将这些发现告诉了我的挚友 H，H 对我表达了信赖，他不仅认为“排查电路”的过程符合科学精神，而且声称新解释最为难能可贵之处在于放弃了无法验证的道德推论，而是通过阶级立场和利益动机进行推理，这具有普适性，同时能在其他时空的历史事件中进行检验。过去，我国的史学总是倾向于将一些重大事件诉诸道德来进行解释，比如某某君主做贼心虚，某某大臣道德高尚，某某阶级生性卑劣，这不但脱离了唯物史观，甚至不具备任何可证伪性以至于难以被视为科学。一个典型的例子就是西晋八王之乱及其之后的五胡乱华，这总是被归咎于司马氏统治者的低合法性，品质败坏和智力低下，稍微合理一点的解释也仅限于对曹魏宗室政策的矫枉过正。但是我们一旦从世界史整体来看，就能够明显地意识到古典帝国的崩溃和少数民族入侵是欧亚大陆普遍发生的社会现象，其范围从不列颠岛一直延伸到朝鲜，将近十个世纪之后，又在中南半岛重演了一次。而牛顿告诉我们，普遍性的现象应当给出普遍性的解释，正是对科学原则的信赖使我能够马上意识到那些旧理论的荒谬可笑。这也是为什么虽然这个看法尚不全面，但是我依然从直觉上对其充满信心，我相信我遵循科学精神，科学原则，依照科学方法继续下去，一定会走到前人不曾到过的位置，见到从来前人不曾见过的景象。